

Extract from *Fall Down 7 Times Get Up 8, A Young Man's Voice from the Silence of Autism* by Naoki Higashida.

'IT'S RAINING!'

A sudden shower arrived out of nowhere. As soon as Mum heard the sound of rain she cried, 'It's raining!' and dashed upstairs to the balcony to gather in the washing without looking out of the window. I just watched her, no doubt seeming a bit vacant. What follows is a chronology of what went on inside my head as the scene unfolded:

- 1) A million *pitter-patter-pitter-patter* sounds.
- 2) I wonder, *What could that noise be?*
- 3) Mum cries, 'It's raining!' *Then the noise must be rain.*
- 4) So I look out of the window...
- 5) ...and watch the rain, mesmerised; yet as I watch now, I hear nothing; it's like a close-up scene of rain in a silent movie.
- 6) Only now does the sound of the rain start to register.
- 7) I seek to connect the concept of 'rain' to its sound; I search for common aspects between all the downpours in my memory and the rain now hammering down outside.
- 8) Upon finding common aspects, I feel relief and reassurance.
- 9) I wonder, *How come it's raining now? It was clear earlier.*
- 10) Up to this point, my mother hadn't crossed my mind. Now she comes downstairs, saying, 'That shower was on us all of a sudden, wasn't it?'
- 11) I recall Mum running to the balcony to save the laundry.
- 12) *How could she realise so quickly that it was raining?*

If I couldn't communicate via my alphabet grid, my questions would go unanswered and I'd be sad to my core about how little I understood. As it is, I was able to consult my mother about how she identified the rain by the sound alone. She told me: 'Well, because that sound's the sound of rain and when it starts raining, we bring in the washing. The weather forecast was saying it might rain today, remember?' I did recall the weather forecast, although to have done so of my own volition would have been impossible. As I remembered the relevant section of the report, the forecaster's words returned and I understood a little more clearly why the rain appeared from nowhere which eased my confusion and frustration.

What remains a mystery is how to infer that it's raining purely from the noise. To me, the sound of rain is an abstract. Identifying the voices of my family or the trill of a phone, the barking of dogs or miaowing of cats, these are relatively easy. Some sounds, however, take me forever to figure out, like the chirruping of cicadas at the start of summer. I sense that I've heard these sounds before but without further clues their origins remain obscure. Even if I could identify the source of rain-noise, making the jump from the thought *It's raining!* to bringing in the laundry would be virtually out of the question. I'd be too occupied just sitting there, entranced.

Rain is a special case. I have certain memories within which rain has left a lasting impression. When I see rain, bitter incidents I have come to associate with it come back to haunt me. Fun things must have happened on rainy days as well, yet somehow it's only the sad scenes which summon themselves up. I have to put a lot of effort into distinguishing 'memory rain' from real rain if I want to avoid triggering bad flash-backs. To do so, my mind tends to give first priority to organising my memories ahead of thinking about what actions I need to take right at this moment.